to get the story—the rest, the ‘desk’ would take care of. Anirudhya took everyone’s leave. He had taken the copy along to share with his wife.

Badhwar stopped him as he passed by his cabin. ‘Your story is reading great, sonny. I am putting it on the cover.’ *India Today*’s managing editor was all smiles and looked happy.

‘The Inside Story of Rajiv Gandhi’s Assassination’ took everyone by surprise. Not that everyone was praising it, but no one had quite expected a newcomer to steal the show, where scores of good stories were being killed on a regular basis for want of space, where special reports had ended up as half-page box items, and where it took years for a reporter to see his or her first story on the cover of the magazine. Suddenly, Anirudhya felt he was getting paid extra attention.

Of course, his friends in the industry called and congratulated him when the Associated Press (AP) wired the story and every single newspaper worth its salt carried it on their front pages—in most cases with his byline. Anirudhya’s in-laws called from Calcutta (now Kolkata) and inquired if *that* Anirudhya Mitra was their son-in-law. While some felt euphoric about it, some felt the story reminded them of ‘sensationalized reporting’. *The Hindu* called the story ‘yellow journalism’ in one of its opinion pieces. The paper’s crime reporter even snidely remarked that it seemed Anirudhya was reporting right from the jungles of Jaffna and not from Madras.

Chief editor Aroon Purie was curious about why *The Hindu* was choosing to attack its reporter. Shekhar Gupta had just returned from Colombo. Purie asked him to cross-check with his sources if something was wrong in Anirudhya’s story. Gupta spoke to his contacts in the CBI and got back with ‘every CBI officer had vouched for the authenticity of the story’. A joint director had told him the ‘story read like a charge sheet’.

Then the former Prime Minister V.P. Singh called Purie. He was shocked to read about the dry run conducted at his public meeting on 12 May in Arkonam. Singh wanted to know if the magazine was sure about the information. Purie put Singh on hold, called Anirudhya and asked if he stood by his story. Anirudhya said he did.